Covered, Not Removed

Soft moderation, attention and the norms of political incivility in short-video feeds

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Study pitch for the Postdoctoral Researcher position
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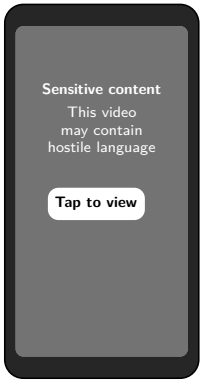
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When platforms label or hide uncivil political videos,
do people look away or look closer?

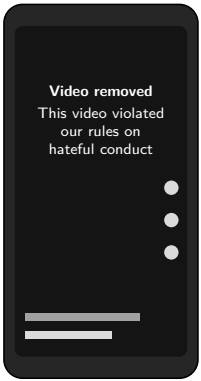
What citizens see: soft moderation in a short-video feed



Label



Interstitial cover



Removal placeholder

Same uncivil political video, three ways of governing whether and how it is seen.

The puzzle: governing visibility, not speech

The setting

- Short video: where young citizens meet politics
- Incivility packaged as **entertainment**
- DSA: visibility restrictions need reasons (Art. 17)

What we know

- Demand for moderation: limited, value-driven
- Labels on *false* news work, no backfire
- Labelling some makes the rest seem truer

1. Does it work, or backfire?

Do people engage **less**, as intended, or **more**: out of curiosity, or seeing censorship of their side?

2. What does it signal?

Does flagging some videos show **where the line is**, so unflagged uncivil content looks acceptable?

Kosmidis & Theocharis 2020; Pradel et al. 2024; Theocharis et al. 2026; Martel & Rand 2024; Pennycook et al. 2020

Theory: four mechanisms, competing predictions

	Compliance	**Reactance**	**Implied acceptability***	**Partisan identity**
Claim	Label signals harm; viewers defer	Restriction raises curiosity	What stays visible looks sanctioned	Moderating my side reads as censorship
Predicts	Less engagement with treated clips	More tap-through by free speech supporters	**More** engagement with **untreated** clips	Backfire, perceived bias on out-party attacks

Democratic stake

Attention and civility norms are democratic infrastructure. Moderation that **amplifies** what it hides, **normalises** what it misses or is read as **partisan** harms the discourse it should protect.

* New mechanism proposed in this study. Brehm 1966; Cialdini et al. 1990; Munger 2016; Pennycook et al. 2020; Papacharissi 2004; Mutz 2015; Theocharis et al. 2026

Design: a mock vertical-video feed, four arms

- Preregistered; short-video users; **DE** first, then UK, US
- Custom-built TikTok-style web app (or Yourfeed); about 30 clips
- Logs swipes, dwell time, tap-through, likes, shares, follows

Within moderated feeds

A **random half** of the uncivil clips is treated, re-randomised per participant: the same clip is treated for some, not for others, so **content is not confounded with intervention**.

No moderation

Label
"This video may contain hostile language"

Interstitial cover
blurred, "tap to view"

Removal placeholder
"removed for violating our rules"

Between subjects: the three interventions from the phone mock-ups, plus a control

Stimuli and outcomes

Stimuli (about 30 clips)

- About 8 **borderline uncivil** political clips, half attacking each camp
- About 8 civil political clips, same topics
- Entertainment fillers
- Rated with the Lab's toxicity typology; no illegal content
- Source: e.g. public PoliTok-DE material

Outcomes

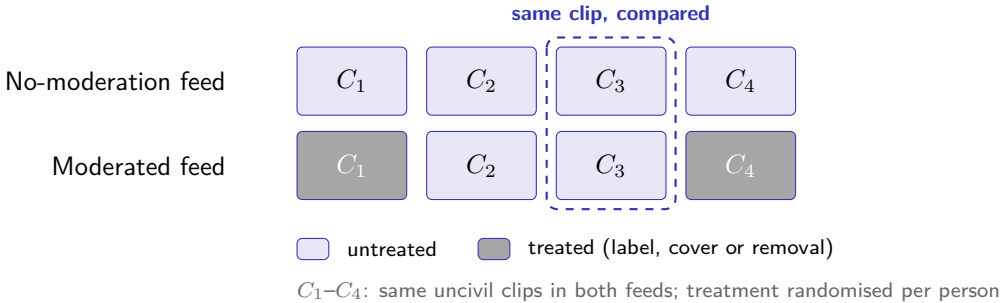
Behaviour (primary): dwell time, skips, tap-through, likes, shares, follows; **spillover**

After the feed: perceived norms, platform bias, support for moderation

Before: party ID, free speech values, short-video use

Ruiz et al. 2026; Pradel et al. 2024; Theocharis et al. 2025, 2026

Identifying "implied acceptability"



If C_3 gains engagement and acceptability when *other* clips are moderated,
moderation governs what it leaves untouched.

Analysis and ethics

Randomised saturation design: spillover (untreated clips vs. control feed) ▪ direct (treated vs. untreated) ▪ total ▪ fixed effects with SEs clustered by participant; mixed models (participant and clip effects) as robustness ▪ **Ethics:** content notes, skip option, debrief

Hypotheses, and what each result would mean

	Mechanism	Hypothesis	If supported ...
H1	Compliance	Treated clips get **less** engagement than in the control feed	soft moderation works without deleting speech
H2	Reactance	Covers get **more** tap-through and engagement, most among strong free speech supporters	"tap to view" amplifies what it hides; prefer labels
H3	Implied acceptability*	Untreated uncivil clips gain engagement and acceptability in moderated feeds	consistency and coverage matter more than intensity
H4	Partisan bias	Moderating attacks on the viewer's opponents raises perceived bias against their side	transparency about rules becomes a democratic necessity

H1 and H2 are competing predictions for the same effect. * New mechanism proposed in this study.

Contribution and fit with the Lab

- **Theory:** moderation as *norm signalling*; implied acceptability
- **Behaviour:** causal evidence on attention to uncivil political short video, beyond misinformation labels and stated preferences
- **Policy:** which visibility restriction curbs attention to incivility without backfire or perceived bias

Lab fit and next steps

- ToxicAInment; PoliTok-DE as potential stimuli
- Reusable open mock short-video feed for the Lab
- Extension: who decided, AI or human?
- Basis for DFG / bidt applications

Look away or look closer? The answer tells us whether soft moderation **protects** democratic discourse or quietly **reshapes** it.

Thank you

Questions and discussion

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Methods appendix

Design and estimands

Two-stage randomisation: (1) feed: control or intervention $k \in \{\text{label, cover, removal}\}$; (2) in moderated feeds, 50% of uncivil clips treated, re-drawn per participant.

Spillover	$E[Y_{ic} \mid \text{untreated}, k] - E[Y_{ic} \mid \text{control}]$
Total	$E[Y_{ic} \mid \text{treated}, k] - E[Y_{ic} \mid \text{control}]$
Direct	Total − Spillover

Estimation

$Y_{ic} = \alpha_c + \sum_k \beta_k T_{ick} + \sum_k \delta_k U_{ick} + \rho\, \text{pos}_{ic} + \varepsilon_{ic}$

T/U: treated / untreated uncivil clip in feed k; α_c: clip fixed effects. δ_k = spillover, β_k = total, $\beta_k - \delta_k$ = direct. OLS (LPM for binary; log dwell); SEs clustered by participant. Robustness: crossed random intercepts (participant, clip).

Measurement

Per clip: dwell, skip, tap-through, like, share, follow. After the feed: re-rate a subset of clips (treated and untreated) for acceptability; norms, perceived bias, support for moderation. Manipulation and attention checks.

Power and inference

N by simulation on pilot variance, powered on the spillover (between-arm, hardest contrast). Corrections within outcome families. Heterogeneity (free speech values, party) descriptive.

Extension: vary saturation (e.g. 25% vs. 75%) to test whether implied acceptability grows with how much is moderated.